# Answering 911: Life in the Hot Seat

## By Caroline Burau

**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 4)** Every day that I sit down at a console in the 911 center, I tell myself that today could be the day. Today could be the day that I take a call that will change me forever. It could be the day that a bell gets rung that I can never un-ring. Someone could die in my ear today and take a piece of me with him. Someone could tell me something unimaginable, and I'll have to imagine it.

**STRANGER:** **(Pg 5)** You're a 911 operator? Wow! I bet you've got some stories!

**OPERATOR:** I get that a lot. The most interesting stories are also the saddest. And you only ***think*** you want to hear them until I tell them to you. They are the stories where mothers and fathers fail their children. They are the stories where friends and lovers do awful things to hurt each other because of drugs or alcohol, or worse, for no real reason at all.

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Or they are the fascinating ways that some people lose their grip on reality. Interesting? Yeah, but not amusing. . . **(Pg 6)** The night Dori Swanson died, I cried.

## INTRODUCTION

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**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 7)** 911?

**GIRL CALLER:** My mom just killed . . . shot herself. Oh my God.

**OPERATOR:** Where's the gun?

**GIRL CALLER:** It's in her hand.

**OPERATOR:** Is she still alive?

**GIRL CALLER:** I don't think so. Oh God! No. She's dead.

**OPERATOR:** How old are you?

**GIRL CALLER:** I'm twelve.

**OPERATOR:** I would never trade places with the cops that had to go out to Dori Swanson's trailer that night. I would never say that I have a harder job than the medics who had to treat her dead body while her three kids wailed and screamed outside. I would never want to be the police chaplain who had to try to

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comfort them. But I will say this: At least they had a minute or two to get ready. Then I talk to her stepfather, who is neither upset nor hysterical. *(to stepfather)* Is she breathing?

**STEPFATHER:** I'm not in the room with her. I don't want to be blamed for anything.

**OPERATOR:** Then, with me still on the line, Dad's cell phone rings. He sets me down and answers it. To whomever is on the line, he says,

**STEPFATHER:** Dori shot herself . . . Yeah. Yeah, no s*** . . . I gotta go. Bye."

**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 8-10)** There are many people in the world just like this man. I never knew that until I took this job. The tough part, the longer you do this job, is remembering that most people ***aren't*** like him. For the next four minutes, I try to convince Dad to keep his three children out of the room where their mother lies dying (or already dead). Despite my efforts, all I hear are screams overlapping screams; I am no more in control of this scene than I am of the moon in the sky. At last, the cops and medics arrive, call a Code 4 (meaning okay, for now), and just like

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that, I'm disconnected from 874 Langer Drive. It's like I've been dangling twenty feet in the air, then somebody cuts my cord, and I'm bracing for the fall. That's the moment I first notice that my body is on fire. My hands and face are burning. My head is thick. I think, Who does that? Who blows their brains out in front of their kids? This is ridiculous.

Later, the shift is over and I think of what it must be like at Dori Swanson's house. I envision a cramped mobile home, maybe one of those single-wide jobs with the rotting wooden siding and the redwood deck. I see the kids' bikes that never got put away for the winter, now partially snow-covered. Outside of the fact that she lived in a trailer, I really don't know any of this. But I took the call; I'm involved. So I put myself there. I imagine it as it must have been, so I can grieve it, then maybe let it go.

Inside, I see the dirt-soaked beige carpet and the second-hand furniture; the TV that's always on. I see the overflowing ashtrays, and the filth, and the

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empty box of wine the chaplain later told me she drank that day. I see kids' drawings taped onto the refrigerator. I see five lives that will never be the same. Six. I see the bedroom where Dori killed herself, just briefly, but I don't stay there long. I wonder if what the cops saw at the scene is more or less horrifying than the image in my head. I never met Dori Swanson, but I wish she had found ***something*** worth living for in that trailer.

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**OPERATOR: (Pg 198)** 911?

**CALLER:** *(female screaming hysterically)* He's hitting me! He's hitting me and he won't leave me alone!

**OPERATOR: (Pg 146)** 911?

**CALLER:** *(male out of breath)* Everybody thinks I hit my girlfriend and they called the cops and I ran because I was scared, but I didn't hit her.

**OPERATOR: (Pg 202-203)** Someday, I'm going to move out of this town. I can't even take a walk anymore without passing ten house that I've sent police to for come medical or domestic or other. Or maybe, someday, I'll quit. . . [but] vow to hang on a little while longer. I like helping people.

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**OPERATOR: (Pg 53-55)** 911?

**DARIUS:** I want someone to come arrest my mom. She's doing drugs.

**OPERATOR:** She's doing drugs right now?

**DARIUS:** Yeah, she locked herself in the bathroom and she's smoking crack. She does it all the time.

**OPERATOR:** What's your name? How old are you?

**DARIUS:** Darius . . . Fourteen

**OPERATOR:** Okay, we have a couple squads on the way, but I want you to stay on the phone with me so I know you're okay 'til they get there. Does she have any weapons?

**DARIUS:** No . . . *(to Mom in the bathroom) Mom, I told you I's going to call! I don't want you to get high anymore!*

**OPERATOR:** Is she mad at you for calling?

**DARIUS:** Yeah. But I'm tired of this stuff.

**OPERATOR:** Of course you are. You're very brave for calling. Is she going to fight the cops, do you think?

**DARIUS:** I don't know. She's different when she's smoking crack. Are they going to hurt her?

**OPERATOR:** *(to audience)* I've been trained never to

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make promises on behalf of the officers. If she fights, they might throw her on the floor, kneel on her back, and cuff her. Is it going to hurt? Probably. I hope she doesn't fight. If she gets hurt, will Darius ever call us again, even if he needs us? *(to Darius)* I don't think so, Darius. *(to audience)* I wish I could hug the kid. He trusted me with his mom.

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**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 143)** 911?

**CALLER:** *(whispering)* There's someone at the back door trying to get into my house

**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 129)** 911?

**CALLER:** *(older lady)* I want someone to come out here and look at what my neighbor is doing to me. She waits for me to leave, then she comes in and pees in my laundry basket. She thinks I don't know it's her. But I ***know***.

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**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 58-59)** 911?

**CALLER:** Yeah, we want to make a report for our son. He says he was molested by a guy from our church, and the guy has admitted to it already.

**OPERATOR:** How old is your son?

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**CALLER:** He's six.

**OPERATOR:** Does the suspect know you're calling police?

**CALLER:** Yes, he's here with us.

**OPERATOR:** *(to audience)* The guy is a drifter, sixty-seven years old. We run his criminal history. He has seven prior arrests and convictions for molesting children in all different parts of the country. "Penetration" is the word used to say that he has had sex with boys. "Contributing to the delinquency of" means that he gave them drugs or alcohol. "Failure to comply" means he never went to his court-ordered sex-offender treatment. Some of his victims are adults now. He is almost begging to be thrown back into prison. Maybe it's the only way he knows how to be saved from hurting children. Maybe he needs the roof over his head.

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**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 56)** 911?

**AMBER:** *(calm and blasé)* My name is Amber Gillis. My husband was using a table saw and cut two of his fingers off. We've got the fingers right here.

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**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 9)** 911?

**CALLER:** *(elderly man)* My neighbor's clarinet is keeping me up. It's 8:30 PM, for God's sake!

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**OPERATOR:** **(Pg 136 -138)** Nine . . . *(to audience)* The phone disconnects before I can say all three numbers. When I call back, a young woman answers. She is out of breath, and there is a baby wailing in the background. *(to caller)* This is the sheriff's department. Is everything okay?

**JAIME:** Um, I just wanted him to leave, that's all.

**OPERATOR:** What happened?

**JAIME:** He hit me in the head and slammed me up against the wall.

**OPERATOR:** Is he still there? Why did you hang up?

**JAIME:** He's still here, but he took the phone away from me when I tried to call.

**OPERATOR:** *(to audience)* As I listen, the two lovers argue back and forth about whether he really hit her. Then it turns quiet, except for the baby. *(to Jaime)* Jamie? Jamie, what's going on?

**JAIME:** *(to man, begging)* Don't!

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**MAN:** I'm going to do it. It's time for me to die.

**OPERATOR:** Jamie, what does he have? *(thinking aloud)* ***A gun? A knife? A bomb? What?*** *(to audience)* The baby wails and begins to sound out of breath. I've never taken care of an infant for any length of time. I wonder what she needs and wish I could give it to her. Is she hungry? Is she scared? Shouldn't Mom go and hold her now?

After about one minute of this, I begin to realize what Jamie does not: That dips*** ***isn't*** going to kill himself. He just wants her to think that he will. To guys like him, women are necessary for survival. She is a roof over his head and a bed and a body to curl up with at night. He will be as sorry and as suicidal as he needs to be to make sure that he still has her waiting when he pleads guilty to disorderly conduct in front of a disinterested judge, then gets released from jail. So he keeps it up.

Later I learn he was holding a knife to his throat. Must have seen that in a movie or something. Judging by the way she is eating his little act with a spoon, I

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assume he had no trouble going right back to Jamie's apartment the next day. That's what guys like him live on, women who buy their stupid crap. I would love to get him on the phone and tell him to go ahead and do it. I know he won't. But I'd love to say, ***"Go ahead and do it, worm. You don't have the guts."***

He's a sh***head. I can't change it. And she's making her choices. I can't change her. I only have her for these few minutes to do anything to help. He's a big boy and she's a big girl. But when I hang up on Jamie and the cops call a Code 4, one in custody, it's not the man's raspy voice or Jamie's pleas that ring in my ears. It's the baby's cries.

**(Pg 142)** I remind myself frequently: Most people don't treat each other that way. Sometimes I imagine what their live would be like . . . Maybe my female caller later moved back to her mom's house and enrolled in school. Maybe the male got court-ordered into alcohol treatment and it changed his life. It could happen. Growth happens all the time. Good things happen. It's just that nobody calls 911 to tell us

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about it.

*(long beat)* **(Pg 181)** There is a God, but He can't be blamed for all the times that people hurt people. I believe that God loves his children, but He can only do so much for them and to them without stepping on their free will. I pray to God very often to work through me. *(long beat)* . . . [like I said before] **(Pg 5)** The most interesting stories are also the saddest. And you only ***think*** you want to hear them until I tell them to you. . . stories where mothers and fathers fail their children. Stories where friends and lovers do awful things to hurt each other because of drugs or alcohol, or worse, for no real reason at all. *(long beat and a call comes in; wearily)* 911?

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